Q+A

# Art of the Matter

Designer **Sabyasachi Mukherjee** embarks on a multi-year collaboration with The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York



**Q. This is a prestigious partnership, for you and The Met. How did it come about?**

I received an email from The Met and thought it was spam. When I realised it was real, I did a few cartwheels and said, 'Let's go meet them in New York.' I couldn't have said a quicker yes about anything in my life.

**Q. Why choose the Byzantine period for your first Met collection, which is a jewellery line?**

I like cultures that are layered and built on exchange, like the Byzantine. Also, my first collection as a graduation student was inspired by the Silk Route and the Byzantine Empire. For this collaboration with The Met, I wanted to tell a human craft story where India could be a part of it. In the Byzantine collection's Islamic wing, we found some Jahangir coins that were produced in Agra and they found their way into the collection.

**Q. Is Sabyasachi a truly global luxury house now?**

I am very uncomfortable about being labelled either Indian or global because I am a craft brand first. The Met collection is a global collaboration with global ideas but done through the lens of Indian craftsmanship.

**Q. What is the vision behind your new store in Delhi?**

I like to build my stores as experiences because people forget the clothes but remember the experiences. The store is inspired by the winding lanes of North Kolkata, Hogg Market, trams and luxury train travel.

—*with* ***Amit Dixit***